practical as well as personal; game theory was the language spoken by military strategists and operations researchers in the Pentagon, where Everett already had ambitions to work after earning his PhD. Princeton was among the best places in the world to study game theory at the time. Von Neumann, one of the founders of the field, was just down the street at the Institute for Advanced Study, and other game theory giants like Oskar Morgenstern and Albert Tucker were at the university itself. There was also a weekly game theory seminar with lectures from Princeton faculty and visiting luminaries, including John Nash. Everett attended the seminar regularly during his first year, and ultimately wrote and presented a short paper there that went on to be a classic in the field.

When he wasn't occupied by his game theory habit, Everett's attention was increasingly captured by quantum physics. Most graduate courses on quantum physics in the United States at the time hardly discussed the puzzles at the heart of the subject; the course Everett took in his first year at Princeton was no exception. But reading both von Neumann's classic textbook and Bohm's newer one, Everett saw there was a problem lurking at the heart of the theory. Von Neumann's textbook made it clear that wave function collapse was separate from the Schrödinger equation, something extra added to make sense of the theory. But where did it come from? Bohm's book, with its valiant attempt to defend the Copenhagen interpretation, made it clear to Everett that the usual way of thinking about quantum physics couldn't answer that question. Bohm's pilot-wave papers, meanwhile, provided a concrete alternative to the standard view. Working on that kind of research problem was disreputable—independently of the fact that Bohm himself was politically radioactive at the time—but Everett didn't particularly care about what was or wasn't reputable. And Einstein's disparaging attitude toward the Copenhagen interpretation made it easier to think about challenging it—as did the fact that several other experts on the foundations of quantum physics in Princeton at the time, like Wigner and von Neumann, didn't always see eye to eye with Bohr.

Meanwhile, one of Everett's professors, John Wheeler, was obsessed with his own disreputable problem, general relativity. Despite the theory's universal acceptance, it wasn't seen as a reasonable field of research at the time. Wheeler was interested in the same problem Einstein was trying to solve: marrying general relativity to quantum physics in a single theory of